Erev Yom Kippur • Diburim

Yom HaKippurim

Carrying for Each Other, Into One Sukkah

Itzumo Shel Yom · Vidui · Nisayon · Simchah

I. Entering the Day

It is Erev Yom Kippur. I am walking my dog right now. It is beautiful outside. My house smells delicious, with my wife and my daughter making kreplach, the food we traditionally eat on Erev Yom Kippur. And here we are, getting ready to go into Yom Kippur, Yom HaKippurim, the holiest day of the year.

In the times of the Beis HaMikdash, and may it be rebuilt bimheirah b'yameinu, the Kohen Gadol would enter the Kodesh HaKodashim on Yom Kippur and say the Shem HaMeforash. But the Kohen Gadol is not really the one doing the kapparah for us. He is acting as a shaliach, as a messenger, as a helper and a guide to bring about the teshuvah that we ourselves are doing.

The day itself has a unique power of kaparah. Chazal speak about itzumo shel yom, the very essence of the day itself having the power to atone. That does not mean we sit back and do nothing. We still have our avodah. We still have teshuvah. We still have vidui. We still have to confront who we are and what we have done. But there is something extraordinary here. We are not creating Yom Kippur. We are entering Yom Kippur. Hashem gives us a day whose very essence is kaparah, and then asks us to step inside that day and do our avodah within it.

It is a fascinating day to learn, to go through on the deepest levels, through the sugya, the halachos, the mefarshim, the inyanim, Kabbalah and Chassidus. What changes in this world on this day is wild. But sometimes we need a simpler reminder of what we are doing and what the day actually means.

II. A Conversation That Almost Broke My Heart

I had a conversation today that broke my heart. Someone told me that they do not want to go through Yom Kippur. That they feel the dinim, the judgments, are all then sealed and that they feel they have already been through a great deal of punishment over the last year in their life.

But as we go from Yom Kippur to Yom Kippur, it is a different message every single year, because every year we are a different person.

Directly connected to this, yesterday, on Shabbos, Liba Esther asked Rav Channen a question: why do we learn Sefer Yonah every year? To this he gave two answers. One is that every time we learn Yonah we learn it differently. We go through it differently. We experience it differently. We can go deeper and deeper inside the sefer.

Separately, and perhaps more importantly, every time we go through it we are a different person. We are a different guf. The body changes. The mind changes. Relationships change, emotional capacities change, even the way the brain functions changes. Who a person is today, going through Sefer Yonah, is not who he was a year ago, and not even who he was yesterday. We are different people from one day to the next.

The pain a person may have experienced over the last year does not mean pain for this coming year. The dinim of last year do not mean the same dinim this year.

III. Bagadnu, Not Bagadti

There is an irony in all of this when we come to vidui. We say vidui so many times on Yom Kippur, over and over:

אָשַׁמְנוּ, בָּגַדְנוּ, גָּזַלְנוּ׃

"We have become guilty, we have betrayed, we have stolen."

That does not mean we personally did each of those aveiros. Maybe we did, maybe we did not. But the whole thing is about the nu. It is not bagadti. It is bagadnu. There is a klal here.

On one side, yes, there is individual din and individual teshuva. But then there is also the larger reality, the larger kahal, the impact of the fact that we are doing this together. Ish es re'eihu ya'azoru. As we say by Rosh Hashanah, this is an us thing. It is a “we” thing. We are a group, individuals going through the olam together, and we have to take a level of achrayus, responsibility” for one another.

IV. When the Nisayon Is Entrusted

It could be, and I am not going to say that it is, but it could be that when a person is going through something, when a person is suffering, there are multiple sides to it. On one side, it could be a challenge, a test, given by Hashem. Think of Avraham at the Akeidah. When Hashem asks him to bring his son Yitzchak, Avraham does not refuse, does not bargain, does not look for a way out. He goes. I am not sure I would be able to do it. But that is where the Torah takes us.

Another side is that there is an avodah that must be done and Hashem will only give it to those who can do those avodahs. The Baal Shem Tov teaches that when a person is in the lowest of low places and cannot seem to get out of it, it is because there are nitzotzos, sparks, that they are there to pick up. That means they have a tafkid. They were chosen for it.

It may seem, chas v'shalom, like a punishment. It really might. But as we have learned, and as we discussed with Rav Channen, Hashem wants us to succeed and He is always giving us the tools to succeed. Success, though, may not be our definition of success. The success is: what does Hashem need from me for this world to exist and to move forward? Sometimes the suffering we as individuals have to go through is not only about us. Sometimes there is something larger that needs to happen in the world, some avodah, some tikkun, something we may not even be capable of seeing. And perhaps Hashem gives that nisayon specifically to the person who has the ability to carry it.

Not because it does not hurt. It can hurt. Not because we understand why. We may never understand why. But instead of asking, why is this happening to me, there is another way to look at it. Hashem has entrusted something to this person. There is something here that only he can carry, something only he can accomplish. That changes the question entirely. The nisayon may still be painful, but it does not have to mean punishment. It may mean that a person has been given an avodah.

When the Baal Shem Tov brought the concept of hashgachah pratis down to such an individualized level, it was not only for the tzaddikim. It was for everyone, in everything, in every blade of grass we see and everything we experience. There is a difference between saying, this nisayon is simply on me, and saying, Hashem needs someone to carry this nisayon and He has entrusted it to me. It is still painful. It can still hurt. But the thing that seems completely overwhelming, the thing a person is certain he cannot get past, he actually can. And that is a strange kind of gift. It is the knowledge that Hashem has faith in us, that we can do this, in the same way that we have faith in Him that everything is ultimately for our good.

V. The Asarah Harugei Malchus

We can see this as well as we go through Mussaf. Yom Kippur, by the way, is supposed to be the happiest day of the year. And then during Chazaras HaShatz of Mussaf we reach the martyrs, the Asarah Harugei Malchus. Painful death. Excruciating. It is horrible. It is.

We learn as well that these rabbanim, these tzaddikim, did not even all live at the same time. They were brought down as a mashal. But the story goes exactly to this point. There was a din. A non-Jewish leader said that there was never a punishment against the Shevatim for what they did to Yosef, and that they were all chayav misah. That is a whole conversation of its own, and Mussaf goes through it fully.

They looked through the generations and saw that there was no one who was the correct person, no one who was able to hold on to this mission, until these specific rabbanim, these amazing tzaddikim. A teshuvah had to be done. A painful teshuvah, a horrible teshuvah, but for the well-being of the world, of the olam, for the balance of creation, to keep everything the way it is supposed to be. And they went up, and they even said, yes, this is the true din min haShamayim. They accepted it. They accepted their fate, not as punishment for themselves, but as a tikkun for an aveirah transgressed by somebody else, not even during their own lifetimes.

VI. Taking Ownership for Each Other

The dynamic of Yom Kippur, a day that is a kaparah in itself, is so unique. It does not exist anywhere else. Nobody else has a day that atones for everybody.

We still have to put in our avodah. We still have to do our teshuvah. We still have to go through vidui and understand that I did aveiros. And we also understand that even if I did not, I can take the ownership, and I can alleviate the punishment of somebody else, somebody who cannot. Through this, we can get through Yom Kippur together, so that it becomes such a day of simchah, such a Yom Tov.

VII. Kiddush Levanah and the Turn Toward Simchah

To finish, Rabbi Gerzi was speaking about this over Shabbos. There is a very strong minhag to wait until after Yom Kippur to say Kiddush Levanah. Why? Because we are supposed to be saying Kiddush Levanah in a state of simchah.

We say in all of our chagim:

אַתָּה בְחַרְתָּנוּ מִכָּל הָעַמִּים, אָהַבְתָּ אוֹתָנוּ וְרָצִיתָ בָּנוּ, וְרוֹמַמְתָּנוּ מִכָּל הַלְּשׁוֹנוֹת, וְקִדַּשְׁתָּנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתֶיךָ
"You have chosen us from among all the nations, You have loved us and desired us, You have raised us above all tongues, and You have sanctified us with Your commandments."

The way we are made kadosh within the mitzvos, and the way we are made kadosh in all the chagim, is because Hashem chose us. That is something to be joyous about. We can go through the Gemaras with the conversation of the moon to Hashem, and the balance of light between the moon and the sun, and it can be a little painful, confusing, joyful, empowering, all at once.

And from there we tie it directly into Chag Sukkos, a day that is entirely about simchah. A day, a week, all of it for simchah, for joy, for happiness, all to love and serve Hashem and nothing else. Unlike Rosh Hashanah, where we have the din and all these balances, Sukkos is about simchah. So much so that the nations of the world also have a share in the korbanos brought during this time. And we tie that in through the minhag of beginning to build our sukkah, our sukkas mitzvah, after Yom Kippur, after Kiddush Levanah. It is a process. It is a reality.

VIII. One Sukkah, B'Yachad

And the goal is that we can all sit in the sukkah. Even if I am saying bagadnu rather than bagadti, and even if I did not do that particular thing, maybe there is somebody here who did. And I did something too.

Immediately after Yom Kippur, though, we have all had our kaparah. We have all been through it, or not. We have all come out the other side victorious, successful, glorious. And with that, what do we do? We can put aside our individuality. We can know that we took on for each other, that we held onto each other's dinim and helped each other through teshuvah.

And then, and only then, can we really and truly sit in one sukkah, all of us together. Everyone sitting b'yachad. No judgment from one to another. No doubt. Just sitting b'simchah, b'yachad.

May we all have a wonderful, blessed, beautiful, simchahdik Yom Kippur.

חזק ואחזק

G'mar Chasimah Tovah

Reflection Questions

- *Am I entering this Yom Kippur as the person I am today, or am I carrying last year's dinim into a day that is meant to meet me where I am now?*
- *Liba Esther asked why we learn Sefer Yonah every year. What is different about me this year that will make me learn it differently than I did last Yom Kippur?*
- *When I say bagadnu rather than bagadti, whose burden am I helping to carry? Is there someone in my kahal whose din I can take onto my own shoulders this year?*
- *Is there a nisayon in my life that I have been experiencing as punishment? What would change if I understood it as something Hashem entrusted to me because I am capable of carrying it?*
- *The Asarah Harugei Malchus accepted a tikkun for an aveirah that was not their own and not even from their lifetime. Where in my life am I being asked to repair something I did not break?*
- *Yom Kippur is meant to be the happiest day of the year, and it leads directly into building the sukkah. What would it take for me to walk out of Ne'ilah in genuine simchah rather than only in exhaustion?*